Q+A

GETTING INTO THE SPIRIT

AFTER *BHOOT UNCLE* AND *BHOOT AND FRIENDS*, ACTOR **JACKIE SHROFF** HAS AGAIN ESSAYED THE PART OF A GHOST IN ZEE5's RECENTLY RELEASED ROMCOM *ATITHI BHOOTO BHAVA*

Q. Seeing how you've played a ghost multiple times, do you believe in them yourself?
I both believe and don't believe. Everything we've heard about ghosts is probably what makes our minds play tricks on us. When I was much younger, I remember going to Matheran. I had to do the seven-kilometre uphill trek from the train station to the town on my own. At some point, I started hearing the sound of *ghungroos*; there was a scent in the air; and I also glimpsed a sari. All this, we are told, signals the presence of a *bhoot*, but I didn't really see one. I wonder, though—why do ghosts only wear saris and not suits?

Q. Your character in *Atithi...* is a romantic at heart. What's your love language?
I am a very simple person. When I was younger, we would cut paper in the shape of hearts, paint it red and write poetry. You'd send letters in scented envelopes and look deep into the eyes of the person you love and give them all your attention. These days, it's all about emojis. But I still write little notes and pick up flowers for my wife, children and friends. It's important to pay attention to the people you love and to show it.

Q. This is your 40th year in the movie business. What do you remember about shooting *Swami Dada*, your debut film with Dev Anand?
I was completely in awe of Dev saab. As a school-going boy, my mother used to style my hair like his. Then, I started watching his movies and liking all his songs. I thought I'd never meet him. He was such a big star after all. But the power of manifestation worked and cast me in a small picture. Even though my role was small, it was a huge deal for me.

Q. Anil Kapoor recently talked about being insecure about you at the beginning of his career. Have you ever been insecure about any other actor?
Nah, I've always believed that everyone had their own space and value. In fact, I was learning from all my co-actors. Anil might have felt that way but we made nine films together. My most cherished films—*Ram Lakhan* and *Parinda*—have been with him.

with Karishma Upadhyay



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